

The Wonderful World of Manipulative Marketing

A Narrative Playground for Awareness and Learning about Influence in the Digital Age

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1 Introduction

Marketing has always been a part of human exchange. It was once a relatively simple practice: understanding customer needs, communicating value, and building relationships. But the past two decades have transformed this landscape beyond recognition. The rise of digital platforms, the ubiquity of personal devices, and the rapid evolution of data-driven technologies have created an environment where marketing is no longer a set of discrete actions. It has become a continuous, adaptive system that follows people throughout their daily lives.

Today, individuals live in what researchers call the “attention economy,” a competitive arena where businesses fight for every second of human focus. Algorithms have become the new intermediaries of influence. They track, predict, and shape behaviour at scales and speeds that were unimaginable only a generation ago. Firms now run thousands of experiments every day—A/B tests that optimize messages, prices, designs, and emotions in real time. These systems are remarkably effective at maximizing engagement, conversion, and profit. Yet almost none of them consider the long-term consequences for the people on the other side of the screen.

This optimisation-based environment raises important questions. What happens to mental health when every platform is designed to capture attention? What happens to societal values when persuasion becomes invisible, automatic, and personalised? What happens to the planet when consumption is continually nudged upward by algorithms tuned for short-term business metrics?

These questions are rarely addressed in the daily operations of firms. Not because people in marketing are malicious, but because the structure of the system pushes businesses toward increasingly aggressive and effective tactics. When one’s competitors optimize every detail of their digital experience, there is pressure to do the same—or risk being left behind. The result is an ecosystem where influence grows more sophisticated while reflection about its consequences remains limited.

It is within this context that the *Wonderful World of Manipulative Marketing* (WWMM) emerges. WWMM is designed with two complementary ambitions. First, it aims to raise awareness among individuals by revealing how modern influence works in practice, helping people recognise the mechanisms that shape their daily decisions. Second, it creates a space where researchers can explore, illustrate, and communicate these mechanisms through an engag-

ing, narrative-based environment. Rather than lecturing about manipulation, WWMM shows it—inviting people to step into a world where marketing techniques are not hidden, but made visible, playful, and open to exploration.

In this way, WWMM contributes to a broader effort within the *Marketing for Betterment* vision: to reimagine marketing not only as a tool for business optimisation, but as a domain of social responsibility, awareness, and human empowerment.

2 Why Manipulative Marketing Persists: Three Structural Challenges

Despite growing public concern about digital well-being, manipulative marketing remains deeply woven into the fabric of today’s digital world. It is not sustained by a single cause, nor by ill-intentioned actors, but by a set of structural challenges that reinforce each other. Over time, these forces have created an equilibrium where manipulation becomes normalised, invisible, and often unquestioned. This section outlines three core challenges that keep the current system in place.

2.1 Challenge 1: Limited Awareness and Lack of Consumer Empowerment

Most individuals do not see the mechanics behind digital influence. Modern marketing techniques are subtle, embedded in personalised interfaces, timing, framing, design, and algorithmic curation. People encounter their effects every day, but rarely the methods themselves. Without practical awareness tools or accessible ways to understand how digital persuasion works, consumers are placed in a structurally disadvantaged position.

This lack of visibility makes it difficult for individuals to build psychological autonomy in digital environments. As mental health concerns rise globally—from anxiety and stress to compulsive online behaviours—awareness about manipulative techniques has increased. However, mere awareness is not enough. People need experiential, engaging, and emotionally resonant ways to recognise manipulation in real contexts, not abstract lists of techniques. Without such tools for empowerment, influence remains asymmetrical.

2.2 Challenge 2: Limited Research, Tools, and Standards for Responsible Marketing

Academia has made significant progress in understanding digital behaviour, yet research on the long-term effects of manipulative marketing remains limited. One reason is the lack of realistic experimental environments and publicly available data. Much of what shapes digital life happens inside corporate platforms, where external researchers have little access to design variations, algorithms, or behavioural data.

This gap limits the development of standards for responsible marketing. While interest in ethical design and consumer well-being is growing, there is still no widely accepted framework for evaluating the causal impact of marketing interventions on mental health, autonomy, or long-term well-being. Without robust empirical evidence and accepted scientific methods, policies

remain difficult to implement, and responsibility remains difficult to define.

2.3 Challenge 3: Competitive Pressure and the Absence of Signals for Responsible Marketing

In highly competitive industries, firms face constant pressure to optimize for short-term metrics such as engagement, click-through rate, and conversion. Even companies that wish to adopt more responsible practices often struggle: without credible public signals that distinguish ethical marketing from manipulative tactics, responsible behaviour is difficult to communicate and even harder to reward.

This creates a market equilibrium where businesses that try to reduce manipulative elements risk losing competitive ground, while consumers cannot easily identify or support companies acting responsibly. Over time, manipulative design becomes the default, not because it is consciously chosen, but because it is strategically safer than deviating from industry norms.

2.4 Policies, Progress, and Persistent Gaps

Europe has taken important steps toward regulating digital influence. Initiatives such as the GDPR, the Digital Services Act (DSA), and emerging guidelines on dark patterns reflect a growing recognition that digital environments must be designed with users' rights and well-being in mind. These policies represent meaningful progress.

Yet regulation alone is not enough. Marketing often operates in grey areas where persuasion and manipulation overlap. It is difficult to verify whether companies follow responsible standards when the mechanisms of influence remain hidden and context-dependent. Enforcement is challenging, evidence is limited, and the boundary between acceptable and harmful influence is still contested.

There remains a long journey ahead. To move toward a healthier digital ecosystem, we need to break the normalisation of manipulation, develop scientific tools to measure causal impact, and create signals that allow responsible companies to differentiate themselves.

2.5 Toward a New Direction

Within the *Marketing for Betterment* project, we have initiated several efforts to address these structural challenges. The *Wonderful World of Manipulative Marketing* (WWMM) is one of these initiatives. It is designed to raise awareness, empower autonomous decision-making, break the normality of manipulative practices, and support research in areas such as digital literacy, persuasion effectiveness, and behavioural change.

WWMM offers an engaging way to understand influence, not by lecturing about it, but by making it visible, playful, and experiential. It aims to give individuals the tools to recognise manipulation, while providing researchers with a unique environment to explore how awareness develops and how responsible marketing practices can be encouraged.

3 The Wonderful World of Manipulative Marketing (WWMM)

The *Wonderful World of Manipulative Marketing* (WWMM) was created to address the structural challenges described above by taking a fundamentally different approach to awareness and learning. Instead of explaining marketing techniques through lectures, abstract definitions, or long lists of concepts, WWMM transforms them into an artistic, narrative-based world where people can see, feel, and experience influence directly. It combines creativity, education, and behavioural insight to make the invisible visible.

At the heart of WWMM is a simple belief: people learn best when they are immersed, engaged, and emotionally connected to the material. Research in consumer behaviour has long shown that simply knowing about a manipulative technique does not necessarily protect individuals from it. Awareness delivered in the form of information often remains abstract and disconnected from everyday life. In contrast, WWMM invites individuals into a world where marketing tactics are personified, dramatized, and brought to life, helping people understand them in a more intuitive and memorable way.

WWMM is designed as a playground rather than a classroom. It invites exploration, curiosity, and experimentation. Visitors move through scenes, interact with objects, make choices, and experience how different techniques shape their behaviour. This experiential approach brings influence closer to everyday decision-making, making it easier to recognise, question, and resist when it appears in the real world.

Yet WWMM is more than an educational world. Behind its artistic surface lies a research platform designed to empower scientific inquiry in a domain where data and experimental tools are scarce. The same methodologies that companies use to optimise engagement—such as randomised experiments, A/B testing, and controlled variation—are used here for a different purpose: to explore how awareness develops, which educational approaches are most effective, how people respond to different forms of influence, and how digital and marketing literacy can be strengthened.

This platform enables researchers to test hypotheses, measure behavioural responses, and generate the kinds of causal evidence that are necessary for building standards around responsible marketing. It helps create new data on awareness-building, the impacts of manipulative tactics, and potential defence mechanisms that individuals can use in their daily digital lives. In doing so, WWMM provides a foundation for research that has been difficult to conduct in real digital environments, where design elements are proprietary and behavioural data is rarely accessible.

Beyond research and individual learning, WWMM also creates a shared language for understanding influence, one that is accessible to students, policymakers, educators, and the general public. Its artistic style lowers the barrier to engagement, while its research backbone creates opportunities for rigorous inquiry and evidence-based conversations about responsibility, ethics, and consumer protection.

WWMM is also an evolving project. As new marketing techniques emerge and digital environments change, new characters, scenes, and experimental modules can be added to the world. This flexibility allows WWMM to serve as a living map of influence in the digital age—both a visual and experiential representation of how marketing shapes behaviour and a practical tool for studying how individuals can be empowered.

In essence, WWMM is both an invitation and an infrastructure: an invitation to explore the hidden architecture of influence and reflect on how marketing can evolve toward greater responsibility, and an infrastructure that empowers research on awareness, well-being, and resilience. By blending art, narrative, education, and experimentation, it offers a new way of learning and a new foundation for understanding influence in the digital age.

4 Impact and Applications

The *Wonderful World of Manipulative Marketing* (WWMM) is designed not only as an artistic and educational world, but also as an infrastructure that can create meaningful impact across multiple domains. Its experiential design and research backbone allow it to serve individuals, researchers, educators, and policymakers in complementary ways. By making influence visible and measurable, WWMM helps advance awareness, encourages responsibility, and opens new possibilities for studying how digital environments shape behaviour. This section describes its main areas of impact.

4.1 For Research

WWMM provides a rare opportunity for scientific investigation in a field where realistic experimental tools, behavioural data, and access to design variations are extremely limited. Most digital platforms do not allow external researchers to run experiments, observe interface manipulations, or test behavioural hypotheses. WWMM helps fill this gap.

Because it includes a research layer capable of running controlled experiments, randomised variations, and A/B tests, WWMM enables researchers to study questions that have been difficult or impossible to explore in real digital environments. For example, scholars can test which forms of awareness-building are most effective, how different manipulative techniques shape behaviour, how people develop resilience over time, or how educational interventions influence digital and marketing literacy.

This creates a foundation for building empirical evidence in a field that urgently needs it. The data generated within WWMM can support academic research on manipulation, attention, digital well-being, and responsible marketing practices. Over time, this can help establish scientific standards, inform new theories, and provide policymakers with evidence when evaluating ethical guidelines for industry.

4.2 For Education and Public Awareness

One of WWMM's core missions is to raise awareness among individuals. Instead of teaching people about manipulative marketing through passive explanations, it uses narrative, interaction, and artistic representation to create more memorable and intuitive understanding.

This makes WWMM a valuable tool for educators, universities, and organisations focused on digital literacy. It can be integrated into courses on marketing, consumer behaviour, ethics, behavioural science, digital well-being, or communication. Students can explore the world, discuss what they experienced, and connect those experiences to theory. Because of its accessible

and playful design, WWMM also works well in workshops, public seminars, and community programmes.

By allowing people to experience influence directly rather than learning about it abstractly, WWMM helps them recognise these techniques in their daily lives. This can support more autonomous decision-making, reduce the normalisation of manipulative practices, and create demand for greater transparency and responsibility from companies.

4.3 For Policy and Regulation

WWMM also has potential applications in policymaking and regulatory discussions. Policymakers often face difficulty distinguishing acceptable persuasion from harmful manipulation, partly because the mechanisms of influence are context-dependent and difficult to visualise. Without shared reference points, conversations about responsibility can remain abstract or fragmented.

WWMM offers a concrete way to illustrate these mechanisms. Policymakers can explore representations of manipulative techniques, see how they operate, and observe how people respond to them. This can help ground debates about fairness, transparency, and acceptable design practices. Furthermore, because the research platform allows the testing of different awareness interventions, WWMM can contribute evidence about what kinds of educational or design approaches are most effective at improving autonomy and digital well-being.

In the long run, WWMM can support the development of guidelines, standards, and signals for responsible marketing. It provides a space where regulators, researchers, and educators can share a common understanding of influence—making it easier to evaluate practices, communicate expectations, and encourage companies to adopt more responsible approaches.

5 WWMM and ESSEC Business School

The *Wonderful World of Manipulative Marketing* (WWMM) also carries a special connection to ESSEC Business School. The first version of the project was created by the incoming cohort of ESSEC students in the CCM programme. With only a few days of preparation and very limited experience in marketing, coding, or design, these students used generative AI tools to build the narrative world and assemble the first version of the website. Their work captured both the spirit and the potential of the project, and it received the *Best Content Award* in the CCM programme in 2025.

This experience highlights two important strengths of ESSEC. First, it reflects the creativity, curiosity, and adaptability of its students. Second, it demonstrates how generative AI can serve as a powerful tool for learning, experimentation, and rapid prototyping. After just five days of training, the students were able to produce a complete, functional version of the website in only three days. This combination of human imagination and AI support shows how quickly ideas can materialise when students are empowered with modern tools and encouraged to explore topics that matter.

At the same time, the current version of WWMM is only the beginning. There is still a great deal to improve: the depth of the stories, the clarity of the characters, the quality of the interactions, and the integration of research modules. Our intention is to continue developing

WWMM with future ESSEC students, turning the project into a living, evolving platform. Each cohort can refine the world, add new scenes, expand the educational content, or help build the research experiments behind it. This process not only strengthens the project, but also reinforces ESSEC’s commitment to experiential and project-based learning.

There is also a clear branding benefit for ESSEC. Because WWMM is creative, accessible, and socially relevant, students naturally share it with friends, peers, and younger students. This gives ESSEC visibility among an important audience: high school students preparing for competitive entrance exams and deciding between top French business schools such as ESSEC, HEC, and others. When prospective students see that projects like WWMM are developed at ESSEC, it sends a strong signal about the school’s values—encouraging creativity, engaging with societal issues, and empowering students to use technology in responsible and innovative ways.

Finally, WWMM creates opportunities for collaboration with non-profits, universities, research centres, and policymakers. Its combination of artistic storytelling and research potential makes it an appealing platform for joint initiatives on digital well-being, responsible marketing, public awareness, and educational innovation. These partnerships can strengthen ESSEC’s visibility, expand its network, and position the school as an active contributor to the broader conversation about influence and responsibility in the digital age.

In this way, WWMM supports ESSEC on several levels: it embodies the school’s values, showcases its students, generates learning opportunities, enhances its reputation among future applicants, and opens doors for meaningful collaborations. It stands as an example of how creativity, technology, and social responsibility can come together within ESSEC’s academic environment.

6 Conclusion

The *Wonderful World of Manipulative Marketing* (WWMM) brings together art, education, research, and social responsibility to address one of the most important challenges of the digital age: understanding how influence operates and how individuals can be empowered within it. By making manipulation visible, experiential, and measurable, WWMM opens new paths for awareness, scientific inquiry, and responsible marketing practices. It invites individuals to reflect on their daily digital environments, offers researchers a unique platform to study influence, and creates opportunities for collaboration across sectors. As it continues to evolve with the support of ESSEC students and partners, WWMM aims to contribute to a healthier, more transparent, and more human-centered digital future.